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The big games

These are the games that will always loom large in my personal recollections of a colourful career. Some for good reasons … some for bad.

When it comes to high-pressure games, I've always done pretty well. My World Cup average is 56.15 from 23 innings, which I reckon proves my ability to handle the unique pressures of a big game. I'm not entirely sure why I am good at handling these types of games – it's probably a combination of factors. I know I like the glamour that accompanies the big occasion. And I like being on the big stage and in the spotlight. Or perhaps I was just born with the ability to handle pressure.

Sure, I do get a little nervous, but even at school I was always amped to play in front of the crowds on the big occasions. I remember a couple of pretty big rugby games when I was in the Bishops First XV. Some guys in the team would be talking about the size of the crowd while biting their nails, whereas I was like, 'Bring it on, boet!'

I remember playing rugby for the SA Schools team against Nampak Schools (basically the SA Schools B-team) as a curtainraiser before the Springboks took on Australia in 1992. It was a capacity crowd at Newlands and the atmosphere was awesome. I absolutely loved it. Big crowds, all the razzmatazz – I love that sort of thing.

Funnily enough, though, when it comes to semis and finals, I tend to play within myself. Again, I don't know why, but I am not as flashy in those games. I become a little more circumspect and apply a little more *kop*. I also tend to be a little less instinctive. But once I'm 'in' in a final, I genuinely feel I can run the show. I guess some people can handle pressure